

A non-transitive 6-edge-coloured tournament on 9 vertices with a shorter longest colour-avoiding path than any transitive one: an answer to Problem 5.1 of Fox, Sudakov and Wigderson

Machine-generated note (see provenance box)

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Provenance

The mathematics in this note was produced without human intervention, in three stages. (1) The construction and proof were found by the language model gpt-5.6-sol in a single autonomous pass on 2026-08-31, as part of a large sweep over open problems catalogued from arXiv (catalog id 2512.10438__00; original writeup in attacks/2512.10438__00/output.md). (2) An independent adversarial referee agent (claude-fable-5) re-derived every step, compared the problem statement and definitions verbatim with the source paper, re-encoded the tournament and brute-forced all its directed paths, and verified the transitive benchmark $f_{6,5}(9) = 8$ exhaustively over all 6^8 colourings of the consecutive edges; its verdict was CONFIRMED. Its report is reproduced verbatim in [Appendix B](#). (3) On 2026-09-09 the writeup was rewritten into the present note by claude-fable-5.1: the text was reorganised with full proofs in [Appendix A](#), the colouring was tabulated edge by edge (the writeup left the “remaining” edges to colour 1 implicitly), and two clarifications taken from the referee’s report were added and are marked as such (the count of 21 eight-vertex paths, and why the unspecified edge colours are irrelevant). No mathematical content was changed. **No human mathematician has checked this argument.** We circulate it to obtain exactly that: is the proof correct, and is the result new?

Abstract

Fox, Sudakov and Wigderson study, for a q -edge-coloured tournament on N vertices, the longest directed path whose edges miss at least one colour, and denote by $f_{q,q-1}(N)$ the minimum length (in vertices) of such a path over all q -edge-colourings of the transitive N -vertex tournament. Their Problem 5.1 asks whether, for some $q \geq 4$ and N , a *non-transitive* q -edge-coloured tournament on N vertices can have a strictly shorter longest colour-avoiding path than $f_{q,q-1}(N)$. We answer this affirmatively with $(q, N) = (6, 9)$: we show $f_{6,5}(9) = 8$ and exhibit a 6-edge-coloured tournament on 9 vertices containing one directed triangle whose longest colour-avoiding path has 7 vertices.

1 Introduction

Throughout, following [1], the *length* of a directed path is the number of vertices it comprises. Let T be a tournament and χ a colouring of its edges with q colours (not necessarily all used). A directed path is *colour-avoiding* if its edges use at most $q - 1$ of the q colours, i.e. miss at least one colour. Write $p(\chi)$ for the maximum length of a colour-avoiding directed path. Following [1] let $g_{q,q-1}(N)$ be the minimum of $p(\chi)$ over all q -edge-coloured N -vertex tournaments, and

$$f_{q,q-1}(N) = \min_{\chi} p(\chi),$$

the minimum over all q -edge-colourings χ of the *transitive* tournament on N vertices. Trivially $g_{q,q-1}(N) \leq f_{q,q-1}(N)$. For $q = 3$ the inequality can be strict, by a construction of Hamaker and Stein discussed in [1]; for $q \geq 4$ the authors show (their Proposition 1.5) that the vector-sequence constructions which produce such examples cannot work, and they ask:

Problem 1.1 ([1, Problem 5.1]). For some integers $q \geq 4$ and N , does there exist a non-transitive q -edge-coloured N -vertex tournament whose longest colour-avoiding path has strictly fewer than $f_{q,q-1}(N)$ vertices?

The authors write that they do not expect $f_{q,q-1}(N) = g_{q,q-1}(N)$ in general, so an affirmative answer is the anticipated direction. We give one.

Theorem 1.2 (Main theorem). $f_{6,5}(9) = 8$, and there is a 6-edge-coloured non-transitive tournament T on 9 vertices, described explicitly in [Section 3](#), whose longest colour-avoiding directed path has exactly 7 vertices.

Corollary 1.3. [Problem 1.1](#) has an affirmative answer, with $(q, N) = (6, 9)$: the tournament T of [Theorem 1.2](#) satisfies $p(T) = 7 < 8 = f_{6,5}(9)$.

Proof. Immediate from [Theorem 1.2](#), since T is non-transitive (it contains a directed triangle). $\square$

Idea of proof. [Theorem 1.2](#) is the conjunction of [Lemma 2.1](#) ($f_{6,5}(9) = 8$) and [Lemma 3.1](#) ($p(T) = 7$). For the benchmark, the 8-vertex paths of the transitive tournament $v_1 \prec \dots \prec v_9$ are the nine vertex-deleted increasing sequences; if none of them were colour-avoiding, a counting argument on the word of colours of the eight consecutive edges $v_i v_{i+1}$ would force four colours to occur exactly once, at pairwise non-consecutive interior positions, which is impossible in six positions. For the construction, T consists of a transitive triple L , a directed triangle C and a transitive triple R with all edges pointing $L \rightarrow C \rightarrow R$ and $L \rightarrow R$; every 8-vertex path visits the blocks in this order, and the colouring is arranged so that each of the 21 such paths uses all six colours, while the 7-vertex path $\ell_1 \ell_2 \ell_3 x_0 x_1 x_2 r_1$ avoids colour 4.

2 The transitive benchmark

Lemma 2.1. $f_{6,5}(9) = 8$.

Idea of proof. Lower bound. Let $v_1, \dots, v_9$ be the transitive order and $a_i = \chi(v_i v_{i+1})$. If no 8-vertex path is colour-avoiding, then $a_1 \dots a_7$ and $a_2 \dots a_8$ each contain all six colours, so at least four colours occur exactly once in $a_1 \dots a_8$ (singleton positions); positions 1 and 8 cannot be singleton, and two singleton positions cannot be consecutive (deleting the vertex between them removes both colours and adds a single chord, which can restore at most one). Four pairwise non-consecutive positions do not fit in $\{2, \dots, 7\}$. *Upper bound.* Colour the consecutive edges 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 1, 2; the unique 9-vertex path uses all six colours. [\[full proof\]](#)

3 The construction

Let the vertex set be $L \cup C \cup R$ with

$$L = \{\ell_1, \ell_2, \ell_3\}, \quad C = \{x_0, x_1, x_2\}, \quad R = \{r_1, r_2, r_3\},$$

indices of the x_i being read modulo 3. Orient L transitively as $\ell_1 \rightarrow \ell_2 \rightarrow \ell_3$, R transitively as $r_1 \rightarrow r_2 \rightarrow r_3$, C as the directed triangle $x_0 \rightarrow x_1 \rightarrow x_2 \rightarrow x_0$, and every edge between blocks from L to C , from C to R , and from L to R . This is a tournament on 9 vertices, non-transitive because C is a directed triangle.

Put $d_0 = 2, d_1 = 5, d_2 = 6$ (indices modulo 3) and $D = \{d_0, d_1, d_2\} = \{2, 5, 6\}$. The colouring χ is given in [Table 1](#); in words: $\chi(\ell_1 \ell_2) = 1, \chi(\ell_2 \ell_3) = \chi(\ell_1 \ell_3) = 3, \chi(r_1 r_2) = \chi(r_1 r_3) = 4, \chi(r_2 r_3) = 1, \chi(x_i x_{i+1}) = d_i, \chi(\ell_3 x_i) = d_{i-1}, \chi(x_i r_1) = d_i, \chi(\ell_2 x_i) = 3, \chi(x_i r_2) = 4$ for all $i \in \mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$, and every remaining edge (the three edges $\ell_1 x_i$, the three edges $x_i r_3$, and the nine edges from L to R) has colour 1. All six colours occur.

edges	colour	comment
$\ell_1\ell_2$	1	
$\ell_2\ell_3, \ell_1\ell_3$	3	
r_1r_2, r_1r_3	4	
r_2r_3	1	
x_0x_1, x_1x_2, x_2x_0	2, 5, 6	$\chi(x_ix_{i+1}) = d_i$
$\ell_3x_0, \ell_3x_1, \ell_3x_2$	6, 2, 5	$\chi(\ell_3x_i) = d_{i-1}$
x_0r_1, x_1r_1, x_2r_1	2, 5, 6	$\chi(x_ir_1) = d_i$
$\ell_2x_0, \ell_2x_1, \ell_2x_2$	3	
x_0r_2, x_1r_2, x_2r_2	4	
$\ell_1x_0, \ell_1x_1, \ell_1x_2$	1	not used by any path on ≥ 8 vertices
x_0r_3, x_1r_3, x_2r_3	1	not used by any path on ≥ 8 vertices
ℓ_ar_b ($a, b \in \{1, 2, 3\}$)	1	not used by any path on ≥ 8 vertices

Table 1: The 6-edge-colouring χ of T ; all 36 edges are listed (orientation: ℓ 's $\rightarrow x$'s $\rightarrow r$'s, $\ell_1 \rightarrow \ell_2 \rightarrow \ell_3$, $r_1 \rightarrow r_2 \rightarrow r_3$, $x_0 \rightarrow x_1 \rightarrow x_2 \rightarrow x_0$).

Lemma 3.1. *Every directed path of T on 8 or more vertices uses all six colours, and the path $\ell_1\ell_2\ell_3x_0x_1x_2r_1$ has edge colours 1, 3, 6, 2, 5, 6. Hence $p(T) = 7$.*

Idea of proof. Since all inter-block edges point $L \rightarrow C \rightarrow R$, an 8-vertex path omits exactly one vertex and visits L, C, R in this order, the L - and R -parts in their transitive order and the C -part as a cyclic rotation x_i, x_{i+1}, x_{i+2} or as a single edge x_ix_{i+1} . With boundary vertices ℓ_3 and r_1 present, the entry edge, the triangle edges and the exit edge carry the colours $d_{i-1}, d_i, d_{i+1}, d_{i+2}$ (or d_{i-1}, d_i, d_{i+1}), covering D ; a case analysis over the omitted vertex shows that the colours 1, 3, 4 are always present too, using the chords $\ell_1\ell_3, r_1r_3$ and the alternative boundary edges ℓ_2x_i, x_ir_2 when ℓ_2, r_2, ℓ_3 or r_1 is omitted. A 9-vertex path contains an 8-vertex subpath. [\[full proof\]](#)

Proof of Theorem 1.2. Combine [Lemma 2.1](#) and [Lemma 3.1](#). □

4 Remarks

Remark 4.1 (What is and is not answered). [Problem 1.1](#) asks for *some* (q, N) , and is resolved by the single instance $(6, 9)$ with a gap of one vertex. The asymptotic question the authors of [\[1\]](#) also care about, whether $g_{q,q-1}(N)$ is asymptotically smaller than $f_{q,q-1}(N)$ for $q \geq 4$ (for $q = 3$ the gap is a power of N), is not addressed.

Remark 4.2 (Connectivity). T is non-transitive but not strongly connected: its strong components are $\ell_1, \ell_2, \ell_3, \{x_0, x_1, x_2\}, r_1, r_2, r_3$ in this order. [Problem 1.1](#) imposes no connectivity requirement.

Remark 4.3 (No conflict with Proposition 1.5 of the source paper). Proposition 1.5 of [\[1\]](#) concerns the vector setting $((q-1)$ -comparable sets versus $(q-1)$ -increasing sequences) and rules out vector-based constructions for $q \geq 4$; the implication in [\[1\]](#) from vector constructions to tournament bounds is one-directional, so a direct tournament construction such as T is not constrained by it. (Observation taken from the referee's report, [Appendix B](#).)

Remark 4.4 (The unspecified edges). The edges assigned colour 1 “by default” in [Table 1](#) never lie on a directed path with 8 or more vertices: such a path uses only the edges listed in the case analysis of [Lemma 3.1](#). So the conclusion $p(T) \leq 7$ is independent of how they are coloured; the referee's enumeration of all 21 eight-vertex paths confirms this ([Appendix B](#)). The value $p(T) = 7$ was checked by exhaustive search over all directed paths of T with the colouring exactly as tabulated.

Remark 4.5 (Computational verification). The referee ([Appendix B](#)) re-encoded T and found: 36 edges, one per pair; a directed triangle; all six colours used; exactly 21 directed paths on 8 vertices, each using all six colours; longest colour-avoiding path of 7 vertices. Independently, for the benchmark it checked

all $6^8 = 1\,679\,616$ colour words of the consecutive edges of the transitive 9-vertex tournament against a chord-independent criterion implying the existence of a colour-avoiding 8-vertex path, with no failures.

Remark 4.6 (Novelty). The referee’s literature search (September 2026) found no follow-up to [1] resolving [Problem 1.1](#) for $q \geq 4$ and no prior occurrence of this example. This has not been checked by a human.

A Full proofs

Lemma 2.1. $f_{6,5}(9) = 8$.

Proof. Lower bound $f_{6,5}(9) \geq 8$. Let $v_1, \dots, v_9$ be the vertices of the transitive tournament in transitive order ($v_i \rightarrow v_j$ for $i < j$), let χ be any 6-edge-colouring, and put $a_i = \chi(v_i v_{i+1})$ for $1 \leq i \leq 8$. In a transitive tournament every directed path on a set of 8 vertices is the increasing order of that set, so the 8-vertex paths are exactly the nine paths obtained by deleting one vertex from $v_1 v_2 \dots v_9$. Suppose, for a contradiction, that none of them is colour-avoiding, i.e. each uses all six colours.

Deleting v_9 gives the path $v_1 \dots v_8$ with edge colours $a_1 \dots a_7$; deleting v_1 gives $v_2 \dots v_9$ with colours $a_2 \dots a_8$. Both words contain all six colours, hence so does $a_1 \dots a_8$. Call a position $i \in \{1, \dots, 8\}$ a *singleton position* if the colour a_i occurs exactly once in the word $a_1 \dots a_8$. If r colours occur exactly once, the other $6 - r$ colours occur at least twice, so $8 \geq r + 2(6 - r) = 12 - r$ and $r \geq 4$: there are at least four singleton positions.

Position 1 is not singleton: otherwise the path $v_2 \dots v_9$, whose colours are $a_2 \dots a_8$, misses the colour a_1 . Symmetrically position 8 is not singleton.

Two singleton positions i and $i + 1$ cannot both be singleton. Indeed, then $a_i \neq a_{i+1}$ (each occurs once) and $1 \leq i \leq 7$; delete v_{i+1} . The resulting 8-vertex path $v_1 \dots v_i v_{i+2} \dots v_9$ uses the edges of colours a_j , $j \notin \{i, i + 1\}$, together with the single chord $v_i v_{i+2}$. The colours a_i and a_{i+1} occur nowhere else in $a_1 \dots a_8$, and the one chord carries one colour, so at least one of a_i, a_{i+1} is missing from this path, a contradiction.

Hence at least four singleton positions lie in $\{2, \dots, 7\}$ and are pairwise non-consecutive. But a set of pairwise non-consecutive integers in an interval of six consecutive integers has at most three elements. This contradiction shows that every 6-edge-colouring of the transitive 9-vertex tournament has a colour-avoiding path on 8 vertices, i.e. $f_{6,5}(9) \geq 8$.

Upper bound $f_{6,5}(9) \leq 8$. Colour the eight consecutive edges $v_1 v_2, \dots, v_8 v_9$ with 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 1, 2 respectively and the remaining edges arbitrarily. The only directed path on 9 vertices of a transitive tournament is $v_1 \dots v_9$, and its edges use all six colours, so it is not colour-avoiding. Hence $p(\chi) \leq 8$ for this colouring and $f_{6,5}(9) \leq 8$. $\square$

Lemma 3.1. Every directed path of T on 8 or more vertices uses all six colours, and the path $\ell_1 \ell_2 \ell_3 x_0 x_1 x_2 r_1$ has edge colours 1, 3, 6, 2, 5, 6. Hence $p(T) = 7$.

Proof. *Structure of long paths.* Every edge between different blocks points from L to C , from C to R , or from L to R . Hence a directed path visits vertices of L first, then vertices of C , then vertices of R (some of these groups possibly empty). Within L and within R the order is the transitive one; within C , a path through all three vertices is a cyclic rotation x_i, x_{i+1}, x_{i+2} for some $i \in \mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$, and a path through exactly two vertices x_j, x_{j+1} traverses the edge $x_j \rightarrow x_{j+1}$ (the vertex x_{j+2} being omitted). A directed path on 8 vertices therefore omits exactly one of the nine vertices, and is determined by the omitted vertex together with, if all of C is present, the rotation i . (There are thus $3 + 6 \cdot 3 = 21$ such paths; this count is the referee’s, [Appendix B](#), and is not needed below.)

The colours of D . Suppose an 8-vertex path contains ℓ_3 , all of C in the order x_i, x_{i+1}, x_{i+2} , and r_1 . Its four edges $\ell_3 x_i, x_i x_{i+1}, x_{i+1} x_{i+2}, x_{i+2} r_1$ have colours $d_{i-1}, d_i, d_{i+1}, d_{i+2}$, which include all three residues, i.e. all of $D = \{2, 5, 6\}$. If instead the omitted vertex is $x_j \in C$, the path contains

$\ell_3, x_{j+1}, x_{j+2}, r_1$ consecutively; writing $i = j + 1$, the edges $\ell_3 x_i, x_i x_{i+1}, x_{i+1} r_1$ have colours d_{i-1}, d_i, d_{i+1} , again all of D .

The colours 1, 3, 4, and D in the remaining cases. We go through the nine possible omitted vertices.

- x_j omitted ($j \in \mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$): the path is $\ell_1 \ell_2 \ell_3 x_{j+1} x_{j+2} r_1 r_2 r_3$. The L -part contributes $\chi(\ell_1 \ell_2) = 1$, $\chi(\ell_2 \ell_3) = 3$; the R -part contributes $\chi(r_1 r_2) = 4$, $\chi(r_2 r_3) = 1$; D is covered by the previous paragraph.
- ℓ_1 omitted: $\ell_2 \ell_3 x_i x_{i+1} x_{i+2} r_1 r_2 r_3$. Colour 3 from $\ell_2 \ell_3$; 4 and 1 from $r_1 r_2, r_2 r_3$; D from the previous paragraph.
- ℓ_2 omitted: $\ell_1 \ell_3 x_i x_{i+1} x_{i+2} r_1 r_2 r_3$. The chord $\ell_1 \ell_3$ has colour 3; R gives 4, 1; D as before.
- ℓ_3 omitted: $\ell_1 \ell_2 x_i x_{i+1} x_{i+2} r_1 r_2 r_3$. Colour 1 from $\ell_1 \ell_2$, colour 3 from the new boundary edge $\ell_2 x_i$, colours 4, 1 from R . The edges $x_i x_{i+1}, x_{i+1} x_{i+2}, x_{i+2} r_1$ have colours d_i, d_{i+1}, d_{i+2} , all of D .
- r_1 omitted: $\ell_1 \ell_2 \ell_3 x_i x_{i+1} x_{i+2} r_2 r_3$. L gives 1, 3; the new boundary edge $x_{i+2} r_2$ has colour 4; $r_2 r_3$ has colour 1. The edges $\ell_3 x_i, x_i x_{i+1}, x_{i+1} x_{i+2}$ have colours d_{i-1}, d_i, d_{i+1} , all of D .
- r_2 omitted: $\ell_1 \ell_2 \ell_3 x_i x_{i+1} x_{i+2} r_1 r_3$. L gives 1, 3; the chord $r_1 r_3$ has colour 4; D from the previous paragraph.
- r_3 omitted: $\ell_1 \ell_2 \ell_3 x_i x_{i+1} x_{i+2} r_1 r_2$. L gives 1, 3; $r_1 r_2$ has colour 4; D from the previous paragraph.

In every case the path uses $\{1, 3, 4\} \cup D = \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$. A directed path on 9 vertices contains a directed path on 8 vertices (its first eight vertices), whose edge colours form a subset of its own; so it too uses all six colours. Hence no directed path on 8 or more vertices is colour-avoiding, and $p(T) \leq 7$.

The witness. The path $\ell_1 \rightarrow \ell_2 \rightarrow \ell_3 \rightarrow x_0 \rightarrow x_1 \rightarrow x_2 \rightarrow r_1$ is a directed path on 7 vertices with edge colours

$$\begin{aligned} \chi(\ell_1 \ell_2) &= 1, & \chi(\ell_2 \ell_3) &= 3, & \chi(\ell_3 x_0) &= d_2 = 6, \\ \chi(x_0 x_1) &= d_0 = 2, & \chi(x_1 x_2) &= d_1 = 5, & \chi(x_2 r_1) &= d_2 = 6, \end{aligned}$$

which avoid colour 4. Hence $p(T) \geq 7$, and $p(T) = 7$. □

B Report of the LLM referee (verbatim)

The following is the unedited report of the adversarial referee agent (claude-fable-5, 2026-09-02/03) on the *original* writeup. Its step labels (S0, L1–L7, C1–C8) refer to that writeup, not to this note. The scripts it mentions are in `verification/scripts/2512.10438__00/`. Treat it as machine output, not as an authority.

Target: `attacks/2512.10438__00/output.md`, claiming an affirmative resolution of Problem 5.1 of Fox–Sudakov–Wigderson, “Color-avoiding directed paths in tournaments” (arXiv:2512.10438v2), via an explicit 6-edge-colored non-transitive tournament on 9 vertices with longest color-avoiding path on 7 vertices, against a transitive benchmark $f_{\{6,5\}}(9)=8$.

B.1 Interpretation

I fetched arXiv:2512.10438v2 (PDF, 22 pp.) and compared verbatim.

- **Problem 5.1 (paper, p. 21, quoted from the PDF):** “For some integers $q \geq 4$ and N , does there exist a non-transitive q -edge-colored N -vertex tournament whose longest color-avoiding path has strictly fewer than $f_{\{q,q-1\}}(N)$ vertices?” This is exactly the statement the writeup addresses. The catalog page’s transcription also matches.
- **Length convention (paper, p. 1):** “Throughout this paper, by the *length* of a path, we mean the number of vertices it comprises.” The writeup counts vertices. Match.

- **Definition of f (paper, p. 2):** $g_{\{q,r\}}(N)$ is “the minimum, over all q -edge-colored N -vertex tournaments, of the number of vertices in the longest directed path whose edges receive at most r colors”; $f_{\{q,r\}}(N)$ is defined “identically ... except restricting our attention only to q -edge-colorings of the N -vertex transitive tournament.” The writeup’s $f_{\{q,q-1\}}(N) = \min_{\chi} p(\chi)$ over transitive colorings, with $p = \max$ vertices of a path using at most $q-1$ colors, is exactly this. Match.
- **Spirit of the problem.** The problem explicitly asks for “some integers $q \geq 4$ and N ”, so a single finite instance resolves it as posed. This is not a strawman reading: the surrounding text (p. 7 and p. 21) says the authors “do not expect $f_{\{q,q-1\}}(N) = g_{\{q,q-1\}}(N)$ ” and “do not expect [the extremal construction] to be precisely transitive” — an affirmative answer is exactly the direction they anticipated, and the $q=3$ precedent they cite (Hamaker–Stein, giving $G_{\{3,2\}}(7) \geq 19 > 17 = F_{\{3,2\}}(7)$) is itself a finite instance. A reasonable author of the paper would consider the literal Problem 5.1 resolved by this example, while noting that the deeper asymptotic question (behavior of $g_{\{q,q-1\}}$ vs $f_{\{q,q-1\}}$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$, e.g. for the exponent) remains open. The writeup claims only the literal problem.
- The example is non-transitive (contains the 3-cycle $x_0 \rightarrow x_1 \rightarrow x_2 \rightarrow x_0$) but not strongly connected; Problem 5.1 imposes no connectivity condition, and the writeup flags this itself.

Interpretation: fair and intended. interpretation_ok: true.

B.2 Step-by-step findings

step	label	note
S0. Definitions of $p(\chi)$ and $f_{\{q,q-1\}}(N)$	VALID	Matches the paper’s definitions verbatim (vertices convention; min over transitive colorings).
L1. Under “no color-avoiding 8-vertex path”, the words $a_1 \dots a_7$ and $a_2 \dots a_8$ each contain all 6 colors	VALID	Deleting v_9 (resp. v_1) gives an 8-vertex path using exactly edges $a_1 \dots a_7$ (resp. $a_2 \dots a_8$) and no chord; by assumption it uses all 6 colors. In a transitive tournament all 8-vertex paths are exactly the 9 vertex-deleted increasing subsequences.
L2. At least 4 singleton positions in $a_1 \dots a_8$	VALID	All 6 colors occur (L1); if r colors occur once, $8 \geq r + 2(6-r) = 12 - r$, so $r \geq 4$. Re-derived; correct.
L3. Positions 1 and 8 are not singleton	VALID	If a_1 singleton, the path $v_2 \dots v_9$ uses only $a_2 \dots a_8$, missing color a_1 — contradiction; symmetric for a_8 .

step	label	note
L4. No two consecutive singleton positions	VALID	If a_i, a_{i+1} singleton (necessarily distinct colors), deleting v_{i+1} removes both and adds one chord $v_i v_{i+2}$; a single chord color restores at most one of the two, so the 8-vertex path misses a color — contradiction. Chord exists since $2 \leq i+1 \leq 8$.
L5. Contradiction: 4 pairwise non-consecutive positions among $\{2, \dots, 7\}$	VALID	Max independent set in a 6-term interval under non-consecutivity is 3 (e.g. $\{2, 4, 6\}$). Hence $f_{\{6,5\}}(9) \geq 8$.
L6. Upper bound $f_{\{6,5\}}(9) \leq 8$ via word 1,2,3,4,5,6,1,2	VALID	The unique 9-vertex path of a transitive tournament is $v_1 \dots v_9$; its edges use all 6 colors, so no 9-vertex color-avoiding path exists for this coloring, regardless of the “arbitrary” chord colors.
L7. Conclusion $f_{\{6,5\}}(9) = 8$	VALID	L1–L6; independently machine-verified exhaustively (see below).
C1. The construction is a well-defined non-transitive tournament using all 6 colors	VALID	Machine-checked: 36 edges, one per pair; contains a directed triangle; colors $\{1, \dots, 6\}$ all occur.
C2. Every path meeting several blocks traverses $L \rightarrow C \rightarrow R$; 8-vertex paths are vertex-deleted orders, unique up to the C-rotation	VALID	All inter-block edges point $L \rightarrow C, C \rightarrow R, L \rightarrow R$; within-block orders forced (L, R transitive; C-part is a rotation $x_i x_{i+1} x_{i+2}$ or a single edge $x_{j+1} x_{j+2}$). Exactly 21 eight-vertex paths exist (3 omitting a C-vertex, 6×3 omitting an L/R vertex); machine count agrees: 21.
C3. With all of C present and boundaries ℓ_3, r_1 , the four colors $d_{i-1}, d_i, d_{i+1}, d_{i+2}$ cover $D = \{2, 5, 6\}$	VALID	Four consecutive indices mod 3 cover all residues; $\ell_3 x_i = d_{i-1}$, $x_i x_{i+1} = d_i$, $x_{i+1} x_{i+2} = d_{i+1}$, $x_{i+2} r_1 = d_{i+2}$. Re-derived.
C4. With one C-vertex omitted, $\ell_3 x_i, x_i x_{i+1}, x_{i+1} r_1$ give $d_{i-1}, d_i, d_{i+1} = D$	VALID	Re-derived (here $i = j+1$ for omitted x_j).

step	label	note
C5. Case analysis for colors {1,3,4} over the 9 possible omitted vertices (incl. modified boundaries $\ell 2x_i$ color 3 and $x_i r_2$ color 4, chords $\ell 1\ell 3$ color 3, $r1r3$ color 4)	VALID	Re-derived each of the 7 bullets by hand and confirmed by exhaustive machine check: all 21 eight-vertex paths use all six colors.
C6. Any longer path contains a contiguous 8-vertex subpath, hence uses all 6 colors; so $p(T) \leq 7$	VALID	The first 8 vertices of a 9-vertex path form a directed path; a superset of an all-6-colors edge set uses all 6 colors.
C7. Witness path $\ell 1\ell 2\ell 3x_0x_1x_2r_1$ has colors 1,3,6,2,5,6, avoiding color 4; $p(T) = 7$	VALID	Machine-checked: colors exactly [1,3,6,2,5,6]; exhaustive DFS over all directed paths gives longest color-avoiding path = 7 vertices.
C8. Conclusion: $p(T) = 7 < 8 = f_{\{6,5\}}(9)$, answering Problem 5.1 affirmatively with $(q,N) = (6,9)$	VALID	Follows from L7 and C7; matches Problem 5.1 verbatim.

No step is a GAP or ERROR.

B.3 Reference check

The writeup is self-contained (no external theorems are invoked in the proof). I verified every factual claim about the source paper against the fetched PDF of arXiv:2512.10438v2:

- **Problem 5.1** exists on p. 21 and reads exactly as used (quoted above under Interpretation). Confirmed.
- **Definitions of $f_{\{q,r\}}$, $g_{\{q,r\}}$ and the length-in-vertices convention** (pp. 1–2). Confirmed; the writeup’s formalization is equivalent.
- **Proposition 1.5** (p. 6): “Let $q \geq r$ be integers with $r > 2q/3$. Then $F_{\{q,r\}}(n) = G_{\{q,r\}}(n)$ for all n .” This concerns the vector setting (($q-1$)-comparable sets vs ($q-1$)-increasing sequences) and, per the paper’s remark after Problem 5.1, rules out vector-based constructions for $q \geq 4$ — consistent with the catalog context. It does **not** constrain direct tournament constructions like the writeup’s; the paper’s one-way implication
 - (3) (p. 5) goes from vector constructions to tournament upper bounds only, so there is no conflict between Proposition 1.5 and the claimed example.
- **$q = 3$ case** (p. 21): affirmative via Hamaker–Stein ($G_{\{3,2\}}(7) \geq 19$ vs $F_{\{3,2\}}(7) = 17$). Confirmed as background; not load-bearing.
- **Novelty check**: web searches (September 2026) found no follow-up paper or announcement resolving Problem 5.1 for $q \geq 4$, and no prior occurrence of this example. Not already known as far as I can determine.

references_ok: true.

B.4 Computational check

Scripts (reproducible) in `verification/scripts/2512.10438__00/`:

1. `check_construction.py` — encodes the 9-vertex tournament and coloring exactly as in the writeup’s table (remaining edges color 1). Results:
 - 36 edges, exactly one direction per pair (valid tournament);
 - contains a directed triangle (non-transitive); all 6 colors used;
 - exhaustive DFS over **all** directed paths: longest color-avoiding path has 7 vertices (witness $\ell_1\ell_2\ell_3x_0x_1x_2r_1$, colors $\{1,2,3,5,6\}$, avoiding 4);
 - the writeup’s witness path has edge colors exactly $[1,3,6,2,5,6]$;
 - there are exactly **21** eight-vertex directed paths and **every one uses all 6 colors**. So $p(T) = 7$. PASSED.
2. `check_benchmark.py` — verifies $f_{\{6,5\}}(9) = 8$ for **all** colorings, not a sample. Key reduction (checked in the script’s comments): in the transitive tournament on 9 vertices, every path on ≥ 8 vertices uses only consecutive edges $a_1, \dots, a_8$ and at most one 2-chord $v_{\{k-1\}}v_{\{k+1\}}$. For each of the $6^8 = 1,679,616$ consecutive-edge words the script checks the chord-independent sufficient condition: (A) $a_2 \dots a_8$ misses a color, or
 - (B) $a_1 \dots a_7$ misses a color, or (C) for some $k \in \{2, \dots, 8\}$ the word minus positions $k-1, k$ misses ≥ 2 colors (so the single chord cannot restore both). **All 1,679,616 words satisfy A, B or C** (0 failures), proving that every 6-coloring of the transitive 9-vertex tournament — whatever the chord colors — has a color-avoiding 8-vertex path: $f_{\{6,5\}}(9) \geq 8$. The word $1,2,3,4,5,6,1,2$ puts all 6 colors on the unique 9-vertex path, giving $f_{\{6,5\}}(9) \leq 8$. Hence $f_{\{6,5\}}(9) = 8$. PASSED.

Together these machine-verify the entire theorem: $p(T) = 7 < 8 = f_{\{6,5\}}(9)$. `computation_run: true`.

B.5 Caveats

- **Not strongly connected.** The example’s strong components are ordered $\ell_1, \ell_2, \ell_3, \{x_0, x_1, x_2\}, r_1, r_2, r_3$. Problem 5.1 requires only non-transitivity, which holds (one 3-cycle). The writeup discloses this.
- **Minimal non-transitivity.** The tournament differs from transitive by a single reversed edge’s worth of structure (one 3-cycle); this is consistent with the paper’s Theorem 1.2, which forces extremal examples to be $o(1)$ -close to transitive, so no red flag arises from that direction.
- **Literal vs asymptotic.** The problem as posed asks for a single (q, N) ; it is resolved. The natural follow-up the authors would still care about — whether $g_{\{q, q-1\}}(N)$ is asymptotically smaller than $f_{\{q, q-1\}}(N)$ for $q \geq 4$ (e.g. by a power of N , as for $q = 3$) — is *not* addressed by a one-point gap of 1 at $(6, 9)$. The writeup’s verdict line claims only Problem 5.1, which is accurate.
- **Convention dependence.** All quantities are counted in vertices, matching the paper’s stated convention; no off-by-one issue. Colorings need not be surjective in the paper’s definition, but the construction uses all 6 colors, so nothing hinges on this.
- **Unspecified edges.** The writeup colors “remaining” edges with color 1 and claims they are never needed; the exhaustive path check confirms the conclusion holds with this completion (and the ≥ 8 -vertex-path analysis is completion-independent, since such paths never use those edges except the $L \rightarrow R$ chords, which never lie on a path of ≥ 8 vertices here — confirmed by the enumeration of all 21 such paths).
- Degenerate cases ($k = 0/1$ colors, tiny N) do not arise: the claim is a single explicit instance plus an exact benchmark value, both fully checked.

B.6 Referee summary

I set out assuming the writeup was wrong and failed to break it. The interpretation is exactly Problem 5.1 of arXiv:2512.10438v2, quoted verbatim from the paper, in the paper's own vertex-count convention, and the authors' surrounding remarks show an affirmative finite example is precisely what was asked for. Every step of the transitive benchmark proof ($f_{\{6,5\}}(9) = 8$) is valid on re-derivation, and I additionally machine-verified it exhaustively over all 6^8 consecutive-edge words via a chord-independent criterion that covers every coloring. The explicit 9-vertex, 6-colored, non-transitive tournament was independently re-encoded and brute-forced: it is a valid non-transitive tournament, all 21 of its 8-vertex directed paths use all six colors, and its longest color-avoiding path has exactly 7 vertices, avoiding color 4. Hence $p(T) = 7 < 8 = f_{\{6,5\}}(9)$, and Problem 5.1 is answered affirmatively with $(q, N) = (6, 9)$. No prior or follow-up resolution was found in the literature. Verdict: CONFIRMED, high confidence.

References

- [1] J. Fox, B. Sudakov and Y. Wigderson, Color-avoiding directed paths in tournaments, arXiv:2512.10438 (2025; v2 January 2026).